

Viburnum opulus (Caprifoliaceae)

Cramp Bark, Guelder Rose

Native to both North America and Europe, cramp bark was recognized as recently as 1960 in the *US National Formulary* as a sedative remedy for nervous conditions and as an antispasmodic in the treatment of asthma. As its name implies, the herb's primary medicinal use is to relieve cramps and other conditions, such as colic or painful menstruation, caused by overcontraction of muscles.



Cramp bark has distinctive bright red berries in autumn.

Habitat & Cultivation

Cramp bark grows in woodlands, hedges, and thickets in Europe and eastern North America. It is propagated from seed sown in autumn. Bark from the branches is collected in spring and summer, when the plant is in flower.

Related Species

Black haw (*V. prunifolium*, p. 281) is often used interchangeably with cramp bark, but it is thought to have a more specific action on the uterus.

Key Constituents

- Hydroquinones (arbutin)
- Coumarins (scopoletin)
- Tannins (3%)
- Proanthocyanidins
- Polysaccharides

Key Actions

- Antispasmodic
- Sedative
- Astringent
- Relaxant

Research

■ **Active constituents** To date, cramp bark has been poorly researched, and there is also some confusion over which active constituents it contains and which occur in the closely related black haw (*V. prunifolium*).

Traditional & Current Uses■ **Native American remedy**

Cramp bark has a history of use in Native American herbalism. The Meskwaki people took cramp bark for cramps and pains throughout the body, while the Penobscot used it to treat swollen glands and mumps.

■ **Muscle relaxant** Cramp bark is effective at relieving any tense muscle, whether smooth muscle in the intestines, airways, or uterus, or striated muscle (attached to the skeleton) in the limbs or back. It may be taken internally, or applied topically to relieve muscle tension. The herb also treats symptoms arising from excess muscle tension, including breathing difficulties in asthma, and menstrual pain caused by excessive contraction of the uterus. For night cramps and back pain, lobelia (*Lobelia inflata*, p. 110) is often mixed with cramp bark. The herb also relieves constipation, colic, and irritable bowel syndrome, as well as the physical symptoms of nervous tension.

■ **Arthritis** In some cases of arthritis, where joint weakness and pain have caused muscles to contract until they are almost rigid, cramp bark can bring remarkable

relief. As the muscles relax, blood flow to the area improves, waste products such as lactic acid are removed, and normal function can return.

Parts Used

Bark is peeled off the tree in strips during spring and summer. Care must be taken to leave enough bark for the tree to stay alive.



Dried bark



Fresh bark

Key Preparations & Their Uses

Decoction (to make, p. 291). For period pain, take ½ cup (75 ml) every 3 hours.



Tincture (to make, p. 292) is used for long-term treatment of muscular tension. For irritable bowel syndrome, take ½ tsp diluted with hot water twice a day.



Lotion (to make, p. 296) relieves aching muscles. Rub into tense neck and shoulders.

Self-help Uses

- Back pain, p. 313.
- Breathing difficulties, p. 301.
- Cramps & muscle spasms, p. 312.
- Period pain, p. 315.
- Poor circulation to the hands & feet, p. 302.
- Spastic constipation, p. 307.
- Stomach spasm, p. 305.

**Cramp bark**

A deciduous shrub or tree growing to 13 ft (4 m), with lobed leaves, white flowers, and red oval fruit.